Andrés Ruiz Palomino

Technical Designer · Unity · C#

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English: Advanced · Open to full-time remote (USD) · Full US-hours overlap

SUMMARY

Technical designer with a game design degree and 3+ years shipping Unity and C# in small teams, which is what makes the design half work: a system I specify is one I have already had to build. Designs combat and progression systems, archetype and counter frameworks, and the documentation that keeps design decisions traceable and reversible. Currently building a 3D action-combat prototype solo, from its design doctrine down to the code.

CORE SKILLS

Design	Systems design and specification · combat and ability systems · progression and pacing · archetype and counter design · balancing frameworks · design documentation and decision records · playtest-driven iteration
Prototyping	Rapid playable prototypes in Unity · mechanic validation · designer-facing tuning parameters · data-driven content, so a system grows by authoring data instead of writing code
Feel	Camera rigs · hitstop · screen shake · knockback and stagger · coyote time and jump buffering
Implementation	C#, Unity 6, ScriptableObject architecture, state machines, event-driven design, object pooling, UI systems, FMOD, Git · Cocos Creator / TypeScript · GDScript / Godot

EXPERIENCE

Freelance Game Developer · Vortex Studios, via Upwork — Sep 2026 – Present

Three mobile games for one publisher, weekly deliveries · first contract closed with a 5-star review

- Snake Battle Arena is live on Google Play, so every delivery ships as a public update. Added GameAnalytics behind a consent screen so tuning can be argued from session data instead of taste.
- Aqua Match Kingdom (match-3): tuned the feel against a reference title (falling ease, settle bounce, per-column cascade stagger) and gave the client an in-game tuning panel plus an exaggerated preset, so feedback arrives as "more" or "less" instead of numbers.
- What the client keeps coming back for: I find the case the spec does not cover and arrive with the default already decided.

Paid Playtester & Design Critique · Mega Cat Studios (US), ErmanAI (US) — Mar 2026 – Present

- Recorded first-time-player sessions with written critique. For a live Roblox game: the top five fixes in priority order, each tied to a timestamp; the team is now reworking its lobby and tutorial along those lines.

Game Programmer · DOB Studios — Mar 2026 – Aug 2026

"Runies Daycare: Merge & Pets" · live-service Unity 6 mobile game · 12-person team, ~118k LOC

- Root-caused the bug cluster in the project's first vertical slice and found it was a design problem wearing a code problem's clothes: the tutorial had to switch gameplay systems on and off at exact moments, and tutorial intent had never been separated from tutorial implementation.
- Proposed the model that replaced it: small blocks holding one mini-action each, emitting their own events, each declaring its own condition for advancing. Deciding that a tutorial step should own its own advance condition is the design call the rest follows from.
- Built the model into an in-Unity node-graph editor so the team authors tutorials as data. Three of us author with it, every standalone mechanic tutorial ships from it, and a forked variation covers story chapters, so adding a chapter means adding steps rather than writing a new flow.

Unity Developer · GDP Studios — Jul 2025 – Mar 2026

Unity games for physical casino cabinets, published under GMW · 4 titles shipped

- Ran the reskin pipeline for cloned titles (same logic, different art) without letting logic drift between versions; drove optimization work, researched font optimization for the cabinet formats, and introduced an art/UX workflow that cut friction studio-wide.

Technical Artist → Lead Technical Artist → Studio Manager · Zarzilla Games 2023 – 2025

- As Studio Manager: ran a studio of ~15 people across 5 areas (technical art, development, UI/raster art, animation, concept art); supervised development on Gin Rummy Super and two unannounced projects; coordinated schedules, sprint planning and cross-area handoffs.
- Redefined the technical art discipline at the studio: it had been art implementation only, and became a group that also owned the technical work adjacent to art, including tools that sped up the animation team's workflow.
- Stayed hands-on throughout: built the entire visual logic of Treasure Mines, a minigame inside Gin Rummy Super. It is still live in the shipped app, so the work can be opened and played rather than taken on trust.

SELECTED PROJECTS

full detail at arzpal.github.io

Tatemis3D · 3D creature-collector, real-time action combat · solo Jul 2026 – Present

- Designed the elemental reaction system around a combinatorial problem: six elements reacting with each other, plus terrain, plus status effects, is an explosion nobody can balance or teach. Two rules solve it. Each element carries a single verb rather than a list of effects, and when two elements meet the dominant one supplies the verb while the other supplies only the material. The matrix stays at six by six, and a player can predict a reaction they have never seen without opening a wiki.
- Designed the creature roster as five archetypes whose counters close in a pentagon, each defined by how it wins, how it is beaten, and a generating question that decides whether a raw creature idea belongs there. Validated the framework against an existing class taxonomy before committing to it.
- Keep the design decisions traceable: every ruling is dated and attributed in the design docs, open questions are marked as undecided, and superseded rules record what they replaced and when.
- Made the architecture calls the code follows: a creature is data and not code, so abilities are lists of small reusable effects; specified the camera's three dynamic states and the feel layer on top (hitstop, screen shake, hit flash, damage popups scaled by the weight of the hit).

Don't Chicken Out! · party game 2-4P · Raymi Games · lead programmer Sep 2025 – Present

- Designed rubber-band block pooling from a problem the lead designer raised: blocks are pooled per player rank (winning / neutral / losing) so what spawns tracks who is ahead, which keeps a four-player race close without ever telling the player it is helping.
- Exposed platformer feel (jump buffering, coyote time, glide, fall multiplier) through a ScriptableObject so the designer tunes handling directly, without a programmer in the loop.
- Lead programmer on an 8-person team and author of roughly 70% of the game's code: match-flow state machine and rounds, local join for 2-4 players across split keyboard and gamepads, auto-rising camera rig, FMOD integrated from scratch.

Prismonaut · 2D platformer · founder of Naked Dog · 6-person core Dec 2024 – May 2026

- Founded the studio and worked as designer, environment artist and lead technical artist.
- Designed and programmed the game's hazards (slimes, thorn roots, spikes, dirt-ball spawners, tutorial lava sequence), owning both sides of the tuning loop: the rule and the feel of the rule. Introduced several of the game-feel corrections to the character.
- Present start to finish, from prototype through Game Jam Plus incubation to a Steam build.

EDUCATION

Toulouse Lautrec · Game Design & Digital Entertainment 2023

ADDITIONAL

- Keeps a written design doctrine for that prototype: around twenty documents of dated decision records, where each ruling states what it supersedes and which questions it leaves open.
- Playable builds on itch.io for Don't Chicken Out!, Prismonaut and Crust and Conflict; gameplay video for six of the projects at arzpal.github.io.